feature of Indian society that lasts till now as even today only 5 per cent of Indian marriages are inter-caste.[19] Endogamy would be closely associated with village exogamy or the practice of women leaving their villages upon marriage. In this way, marriage migration also became an important route for the circulation of ideas and practices.[20] And because the choice of partners was restricted due to caste, these migrations were not necessarily to the neighbouring village but could involve larger distances. Like the Brownian motion of random movement of particles in a fluid, the Indian subcontinent was also witnessing the spatial mobility of its mostly brown bodies in multiple directions to different villages.

Ancient Migrations: In, Out, Within

The history of migration in ancient India from the middle of the first millennium BCE to circa 1300 CE, covering nearly 2000 years, is one of immigration mainly from central Asia via the north-western passes, instances of emigration to the west and the east, and internal migration accompanying urbanization, colonization and deportation. It is a complex history, of a religion born in India—Buddhism—and exported, of another religion—Jainism—circulating within, and of other faiths such as Christianity, Judaism, Zoroastrianism, and Islam coming in. It is also a history of the rise and fall of countless kingdoms, among which the Mauryan (c. 320 BCE–200 BCE) and Gupta Empires (c. 300 CE–600 CE) stand out for their geographical extents. At the heart of this narrative is a region synonymous with migration in contemporary India's Bihar—but for inmigration, not outmigration.

As per available historical records, the centre of gravity in the political and urban sphere shifted between 2000 BCE and 300 BCE, progressively eastwards from the Indus Valley to the Ganga–Yamuna doab and then to the region surrounding Pataliputra, or present-day Patna in Bihar, eventually the seat of both the Mauryan and Gupta Empires. While there is evidence of human activity throughout the Indo-Gangetic valley even before 2000 BCE,